

NAVARATRI CELEBRATIONS

THE WORSHIP OF POTENT SREE CHAKRA

THE pride of place in Avadhoota Datta Peetham in Mysore belongs naturally to Lord Dattatreya as the presiding deity. In the current Navarathri season, however, Mother Goddess Sri Vidya receives ample prominence, in the form of Sri Chakra Archanam. Sri Swamiji worships Mother Goddess in her various forms like Durga, Saraswathi, Lakshmi and Rajarajeswari.

During the Sharannavarathri celebrations, Poojya Sri Swamiji pays obeisance to Mother Nature as Prakriti and to the Navagrahas or the nine planetary forces. He offers Navadurgi Saptha Rishi Nava Aavarana puja where the worshipper passes through nine fortresses to worship the nine forms of Prakriti Matha (Mother Nature).

The Sree Chakra is deemed to be the abode of the Mother Goddess and manifestations of Gowri, Rajarajeshwari, Durgi Laskmi, Meenakshi, Parashakti, Vishalakshi, Mahasaraswati, Chandi Devi and Shakthi Durgi are invoked for worship in that order from day one to nine during the Navarathri celebrations.

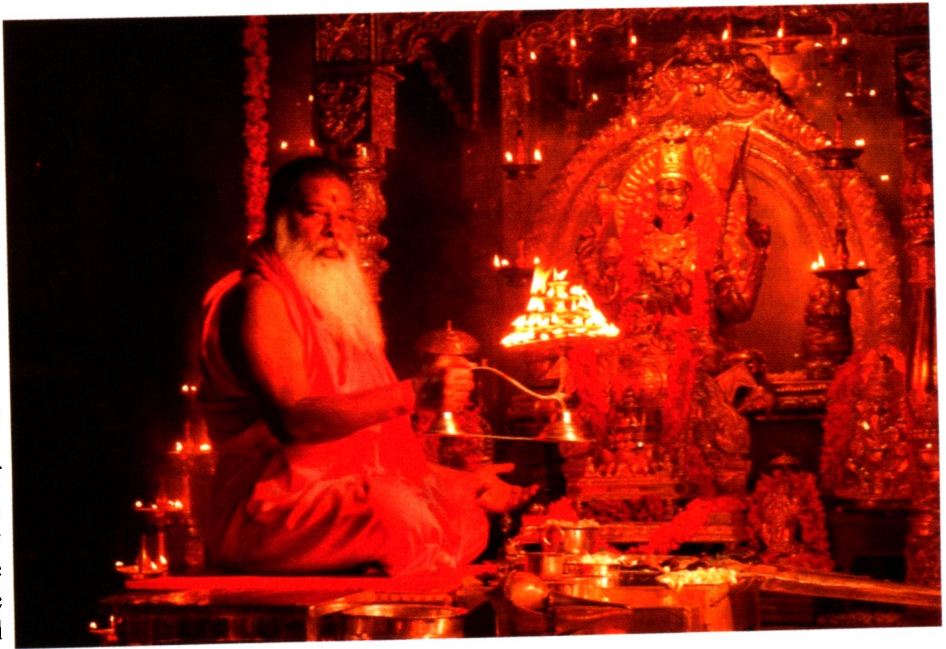
In the course of the celebrations, Poojya Swamiji unravels the mystery of Sree Vidya Upasana, the sacred tradition of worshipping the Mother Goddess. Intellectual and spiritual energy and a sense of integrity radiate from the place of worship. He composes stirring devotional hymns on the spot on the Mother

Goddess and expounds the tenets of our complex philosophy in such a manner that even a layman can understand them with ease.

Sree Vidya Upasana views life underlying every form of matter as one absolute indivisible spirit. All shakthi or energy flows from this spirit of life endowed in every being with its consciousness. This energy permeates everything. The doctrine of Shakthi integrates everything secular and spiritual into one reality symbolized by Mother and thus eliminates all contradictions and conflicts. It impels human vision to see Nature or Prakriti as the Mother Goddess Durga. It underlines the solidarity of the universe, oneness of creation and mankind as well as the divinity of the soul. Sree Vidya Upasana therefore is a valuable acknowledgement of the eternal truth and everyone should strive to realise it. It portrays gods and goddesses as energies conducive to spiritual elevation. During Sharannavarathri, it guides us towards light and away from ignorance. Sri Swamiji emphasizes that knowledge of Nature is the sole means of liberation and that human life is an integral part of Nature. The object of Sree Chakra worship therefore is to gain 'prasannata' or grace of the Mother Goddess.

The Navarathri festival takes place in the month of Ashwiyuja straddling September / October and comprises nine nights of worship and festivities. The custodian deities of the Mother Goddess are invoked and worshipped in accordance with Vedic rituals in the form of *bijaksharas* or seed letters. They are deemed as resident energies (*Sree Chakra nivasinis*) and depicted as live energies.

Nine kalasas or sacred pots representing nine planets are installed around the mantap before the beginning of the pujas. In keeping with tradition, nine types of grains corresponding to planets or mother energies are used in the ceremonies. The traditional Navarathri pujas begin with the



worship of 16 maidens known as Kumari puja. They represent the 16 'Kaalas' and radiances of the moon.

The Navarathri celebrations at the Ganapati Sachchidananda Ashram are replete with grandeur and gaiety. Thousands of devotees throng the Nada Mantapam to witness these nava varana pujas and soak up the spiritual fervour throughout the day. Sri Swamiji follows a rigorous and austere schedule to reach the zenith (bindu) by a kind of an internal travel (Antaryaga) as a blessing to the devotees. Though we witness the outward puja and rituals, the real aim is to invoke the latent power in the body through the various chakras or centres of energy and finally attain 'Bindusamyoga.'

The five elements or 'pancha bhutas' are invoked along with certain other powers, leading to 'Omkaara.' The seven 'Mother powers,' Brahmi, Maheswari, Kaumari, Vaishnavi, Varahi, Indrani and Chamunda are invoked. Sri Swamiji's energies radiate throughout the festival. Demonic nature is inherent in man and it has to be overpowered to uplift the soul. This is possible only by Sadguru's grace. The various pujas performed in strict adherence to Agama rules are meant to invoke blessings for peace and prosperity for the entire world.